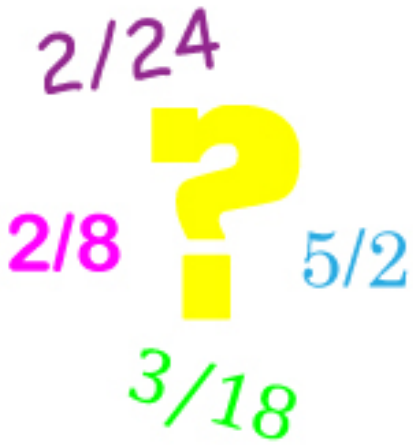

Yarn Counts: What Do Those Numbers Mean?

A Guide to Knitting With Yarn on Cones

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COUNT SYSTEMS

Yarn on cones is often referred to by the yarn count (3/8, 10/2 etc).

By using a traditional Fixed Weight system, knitters and weavers can refer to yarns in a standardized way. Using this system, the thicker the yarn, the lower the count.

For wool, the count is the second number. The number of plies (or folds) is the first number (we will discuss this later)

This example shows multiple plies of an eight count wool.

… the thicker the yarn, the lower the count.

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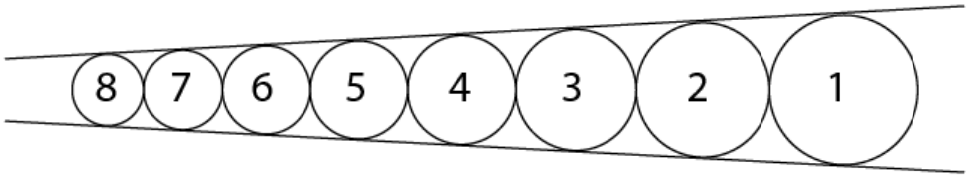
How are the Numbers Established?

Over the years, a number of systems have been developed in the textile industry. Knitters and weavers use the Fixed Weight System.

Fixed Weight System:

- The length is variable and the weight is constant
- The thicker the yarn, the lower the count



In our example, the 2/8 is thinnest and the 4/8 is the thickest

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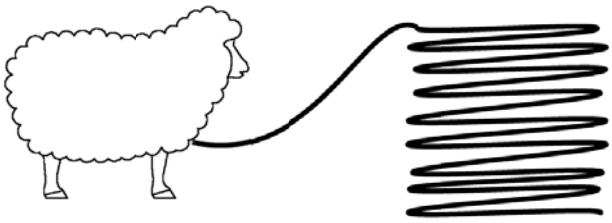
Single Ply

Let's work with worsted wool. Different fibers use different numbers (a chart follows).

Worsted wool is wool that is carded and combed so all the fibers are parallel. **This is not the same as "worsted weight" yarn.**



A pound of wool, spun ONE time sets the basis for this system. It isn't often that spinners and weavers work with wool that has only been spun one time.

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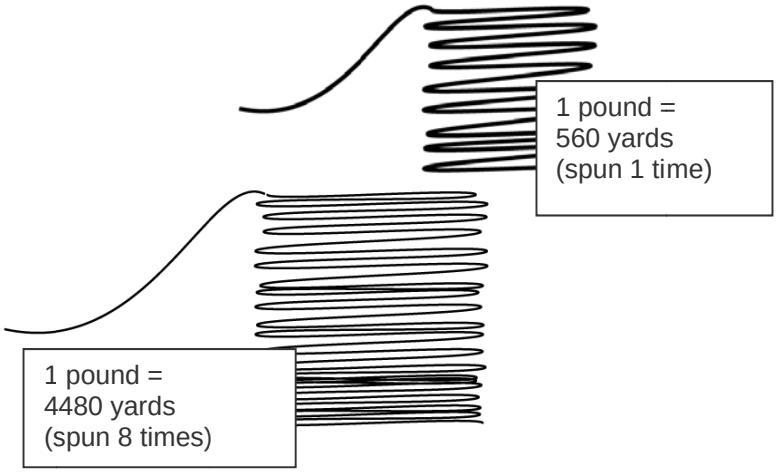
Multiple Plies

When the wool is spun a second (and subsequent times) it is thinner and longer each time.



Using this method, knitters can compare 'apples to apples' no matter what the source of the wool (or the blend of fibers)

Knitters rarely use a single ply of yarn. In the textile arts, spinning is done by taking 2 or more strands that each have a twist to them and putting them together. The strands are twisted together in the opposite direction of the originally spun single ply.

In addition, by using multiply plies, manufacturers can create the wonderful yarns that we love.

Multiple colors and multiple fibers can be spun together. Various techniques can be applied. An example is boucle yarn where one strand is held loosely and allowed to make loops on the other yarn while plying.

Although the number of plies is interesting, the weight of the singles that make up the yarn is what determines the weight of the yarn.

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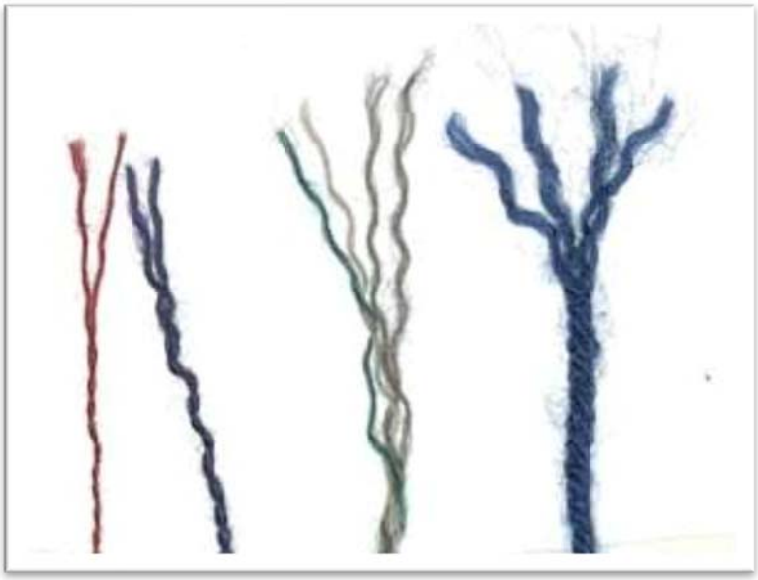
2/24 = 2 plies of 24 weight singles (spun 24 times)

2/18 = 2 plies of 18 weight singles

4/8 = 4 plies of 8 weight singles



By understanding Yarn Counts, you can more easily substitute yarns in patterns and estimate your yarn needs.

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COMPARE 4-PLY YARNS

The term 4-Ply is similar to “worsted weight”, “sport weight”, “fingering weight”. These terms are quite subjective. A fingering weight yarn from one manufacturer is unlikely to be the same as a fingering weight from another source.

Have you ever had someone tell you . . . "I only use 4 ply yarn"?

What does that mean? **4 ply yarns ARE NOT EQUAL!**

Both of these yarns are 4 ply. They each have 4 strands spun together, but they are very different!

The needle on the bottom is from a standard gauge machine and the needle on top is from a mid-gauge machine.

It’s obvious that the top yarn would not knit well on the standard machine (the hooks would catch and split the yarn).

The bottom yarn on the mid gauge would be very open and loose (a design feature?)

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WHAT DOES THIS MEAN FOR YOU?

By understanding Yarn Counts, you can more easily substitute yarns in patterns and estimate your yarn needs.

Worsted Wool *
Fixed Weight System

*Worsted wool is wool that is carded and combed so all the fibers are parallel.

This is not the same as worsted weight yarn.

Get familiar with the yards per pound of your favorite yarns. If a pattern calls for a yarn at a specific weight, you may be able to substitute multiple strands of a thinner yarn to obtain gauge.

Single Ply
560 x count = ypp

1/1	=	560 ypp
1/8	=	4,480 ypp
1/18	=	10,080 ypp
1/24	=	13,440 ypp

2 Ply
(560 x count)/2 = ypp

1/1	=	560 ypp
2/8	=	2,240 ypp
2/18	=	5,040 ypp
2/24	=	6,720 ypp

4 Ply
(560 x count)/4 = ypp

1/1	=	560 ypp
4/8	=	1,120 ypp
4/18	=	2,520 ypp
4/24	=	3,350 ypp

Standard Gauge (4.5mm) ..... 1,200 ypp to 8,000 ypp

Mid-Gauge/Bulky (6 to 9 mm)..... 1,000 ypp and heavier

These are suggested yardages.

The pattern and personal preference determine how you ...

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Balled/Skeined Yarn

When working with yarn in hanks, balls or skeins, you can use this Yarn Count method to determine the yards per pound and compare the yarn weight to yarns that are familiar.

You can then decide if a yarn is appropriate for your gauge of machine.

Standard Gauge Machine

50 Gram Ball
1 pound = approx 450 grams
1 pound = nine 50 gram balls
1 meter = 1.09 yards

EXAMPLE:
50 g ball = 300 meters
50 g ball = 300 x 1.09 = 327 yards
9 balls = (300 x 9) x 1.09 = 2943 yards per pound

100 Gram Ball
1 pound = approx 450 grams
1 pound = 4.5 100 gram balls
1 meter = 1.09 yards

EXAMPLE:
100 g ball = 150 meters
100 g ball = 150 x 1.09 = 163 yards
4.5 balls = (163 x 4.5) x 1.09 = 800 yards per pound

Bulky Gauge Machine

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Other Fibers

Our examples have been based on worsted wool yarn.

Other fibers use different numbers, but the concepts are the same.

Yorkshire Wool	256 ypp
Linen	300 ypp
Worsted	560 ypp
Cotton	840 ypp
Spun Silk	840 ypp

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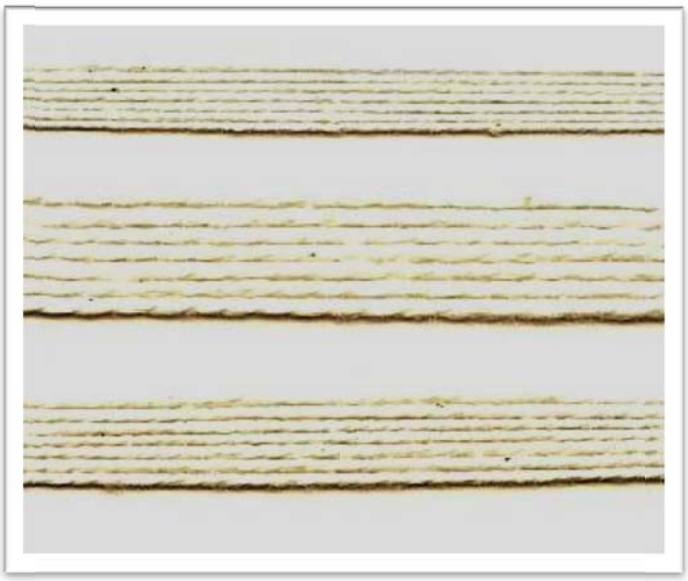
COTTON YARN

Cotton Yarn Counts are based on 840 yards per pound. In addition, the cotton numbering is reversed.

The yarn count is listed first and the plies are listed second.

10/2	4,200 ypp	2 plies of a 10 count single
5/2	2,100 ypp	2 plies of a 5 count single
3/2	1,260 ypp	2 plies of a 3 count single



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A Caveat

All calculations are approximate. Because yarn is made from plant and animal fibers it absorbs moisture in the air that impacts the weight. In addition, it stretches in processing. Different machines used for spinning and plying yarn can produce different results.

Keep in mind that it is unlikely that 2 different one-pound cones will have exactly the same yardage.

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IDENTIFY MYSTERY YARN

The McMorran Yarn Balance is an invaluable tool for weighing and measuring yarn.

It helps you identify the yards per pound of a mystery yarn and allows you to calculate how much yarn is on a cone or in a ball.

Look for the tutorial "Using a McMorran Yarn Balance" in the Knit it Now Learning Library

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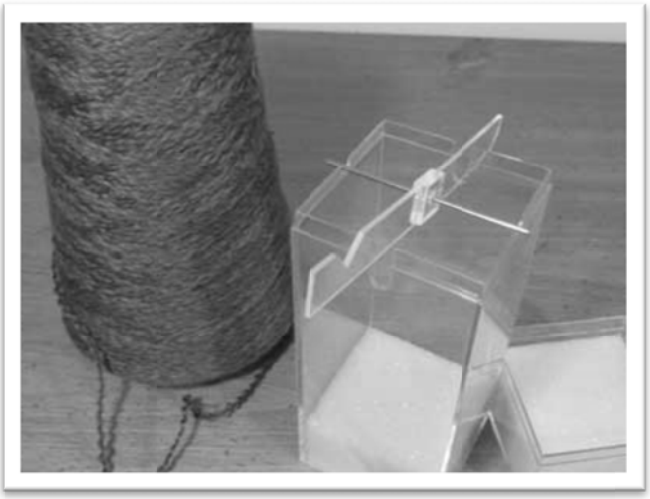

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